were designing the Staircourt House in Talegaon, near Pune, the site was part of a plotted development. So we knew that we may not have good views looking outside the house. Maybe the best thing would be that we face the street. But apart from that, we could end up looking at other houses. In this context, our strategy was to create a court inside, which creates pleasant views within the house itself. The plot size was also quite small, so we couldn't create a large courtyard. Which is where the idea to reimagine the staircase itself as a courtyard emerged. The staircase rises through a double-height volume, drawing daylight deep into the interior and creating a sequence of interconnected spaces across levels that become the social heart of the home. And within the limited space, this helps create a sense of openness, comfort and calm for the residents," shares Chavan. He adds that whatever the context, having a space that is free of clutter is crucial to ease the mind, "One should only build spaces that are absolutely necessary, and keep them clutter-free. That is the first thing that would give you a peaceful home. If your house is filled with a lot of furniture and objects, that itself can make you uncomfortable." Parikh agrees, sharing that "If spaces are decked up completely, there's no room for your personal space to happen. In every home, there needs to be some space for nothingness."



Photograph by VIVEK EADARA

Pune-based architect and founder of Localground, Khushru Irani, also agrees. "I personally would find it difficult to live in a home filled with too much furniture—I prefer larger spaces with fewer objects around," he says. But then, a couple approached him to design their home with a very specific idea that contrasted with this line of thought. "Just like my grandmother, who feels the most comfortable in her cotton sarees, this couple knew exactly what would bring them comfort—being surrounded by objects they had lovingly collected over the years and having specific elements of traditional Kerala homes like the *mugappu* roof, wooden *stambhams* (columns); and intricately carved wooden doors and window frames," says Irani, adding, "They wanted to be involved very deeply in the design process, so much so that they wanted to source almost every single one of these elements for their home themselves."

The couple in question, while from Kerala and moved to Maharashtra a long time ago. They wanted to curate each object in their home themselves, to ensure that each one carried the memory of their homeland. The architects they had met before coming to Irani had not agreed to this level of involvement in the design process. "Something we often forget is that the process of design itself can be anxiety-inducing for homeowners," adds Irani. If the process is stressful in itself, can one truly feel at ease once the space is realised? In Irani's experience, comfort needs to be embedded into the design process much before a single line gets drawn. "I didn't know any other way that one would work with a client. Of course, you would have to collaborate closely. Of course, you would have to create something that this particular person desired and would be happy to live with," he adds. The House of Traditional Elements is a result of this close collaboration. "Every piece of wood in the house is recycled from older buildings. Whenever a set of antique doors or windows would come up for sale, the clients would go there and message us. We would quickly sort of do this mental arithmetic of where we could use these windows or doors in the house. Then we would sort of say, okay, go ahead, buy these. Or don't buy these," shares Irani.

Ultimately, these homes prove that architectural comfort cannot be mass-produced; it is deeply personal and contextual. Whether realised through a barefoot connection to nature, strategic urban light-wells or a collaborative tapestry of cherished memories, a house only succeeds when it aligns with the inner rhythm of its inhabitants.

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